

James 2:14-26, Dead Faith Is a Corpse

Roughly 1,300 words. Scripture NIV, shaded blocks read aloud as they stand.

1. The address

You believe the right things. That is not flattery, I mean it as a description. If I asked you tonight whether there is one God, you would say yes, and you would be correct, and you would not have to think about it.

This passage is going to ask you a question that your correctness cannot answer. Not whether your belief is true. Whether it is alive.

And the reason that question is frightening is that there is no way to answer it by checking your doctrine, because in the case James is about to describe, the doctrine is perfect.

2. The text

Read 2:14-26 whole, no commentary, no annotation while reading. Let it sit for a beat afterward.

3. The difficulty

Now the problem, and I am not going to soften it, because everybody softens it and you can always tell.

Verse 24:

2:24. "You see that a person is considered righteous by what they do and not by faith alone."

Paul, in Romans 3:28:

"For we maintain that a person is justified by faith apart from the works of the law."

Those are not two shades of emphasis. Read plainly, one says you are justified by faith apart from works and the other says you are not justified by faith alone. They use the same words to say opposite things, and they both reach for Abraham to prove it, and they both quote the same verse about Abraham to prove it.

This is not a manufactured problem invented by people looking for trouble. It split the church. Luther called James an epistle of straw and wanted it out of the canon over this. If your answer to it is that the tension is only apparent and we should all calm down, you have not felt the problem yet.

4. The turn

Here is the whole episode in one move.

James tells you which faith he is killing. He tells you five verses before he kills it, and almost nobody reads verse 24 in the light of verse 19.

2:19. "You believe that there is one God. Good! Even the demons believe that, and shudder."

Sit on what he just did. He reaches for the best creed available to a Jew. There is one God. That is the Shema, Deuteronomy 6:4, the line a faithful Israelite says twice a day, the bedrock of the whole religion. James picks the single most correct sentence a human being can say.

And he hands it to demons.

The demons are orthodox. Their theology is not approximate, it is exact, and it is better than yours, because they are not guessing. And what it produces in them is shuddering. Perfect belief. Zero communion.

So when James says "faith alone" in verse 24, he is not reaching for a category he never defined. He defined it in verse 19. The faith he is negating is the demons' faith. Assent. Knowing the proposition is true and signing it.

That is not the thing Paul means by faith, and Paul says so himself:

Galatians 5:6. "The only thing that counts is faith expressing itself through love."

Paul's faith already has the works inside it. It is not assent, it is trust that acts.

So the two men are not making opposite claims about one thing. They are making claims about two different interior acts that share an English word.

5. The pressure

Three tests. If the turn is right, it has to survive all three.

Test one. Does the other word hold up?

If "faith" is two different objects, "works" had better be too, or the fix is half a fix.

Watch what James counts as a work, every single time he gives an example. Verse 16, clothe the naked and feed the hungry. Verse 25, Rahab hides the spies and sends them out safe. Go back to 1:27, look after orphans and widows in their distress.

Every one is a mercy done to a body.

Now Paul's works of the law, in the letters where he actually fights about it.

Circumcision. Food laws. Sabbath. Calendar. The Torah boundary markers, the things that mark off a Jew from a Gentile.

Paul is asking what makes a Gentile a member of the people of God. James is asking whether the faith you claim is alive. Different questions, different objects, same English word twice over.

Test two. Then why these two witnesses?

James proves it with Abraham and Rahab, and if works meant earning, that pairing is insane.

Abraham is the founding insider. The patriarch, father of the nation, the most respectable name a Jew can say. Rahab is the total outsider. Foreign, a woman, a Canaanite, a prostitute. No lineage, no standing, no patron, no ring. In the language of last episode, a person with no face the world would receive.

James sets them side by side and prices them identically. Both considered righteous for what they did, same verdict, same breath.

Which means the thing he is testing for cannot be merit, because these two have nothing comparable to weigh. It has to be something that shows up the same in a patriarch and in

a prostitute. He is testing for life, and life looks the same in both.

And notice that he does this inside his own proof. He refuses to receive the face while arguing. That is 2:1 performed rather than stated.

Test three. The one that should break it.

Both men quote the same verse. Genesis 15:6, Abraham believed God and it was credited to him as righteousness. If they mean opposite things, one of them is misusing it.

They are quoting it about two different days.

Paul reads it where it sits, at Genesis 15, the night God shows him the stars. Before Isaac exists. Before circumcision. Paul's entire point in Romans 4 is the timing, that the credit came first, on nothing but trust.

James reads the same sentence forward to Genesis 22, the knife on the mountain, thirty years later. And listen to his verbs:

2:22-23. "his faith and his actions were working together, and his faith was made complete by what he did. And the scripture was fulfilled that says, 'Abraham believed God...'"

Made complete. Fulfilled. James is not saying Abraham earned the verdict on the mountain. He is saying the sentence written thirty years earlier came true. The faith that was real at fifteen is the faith that walked up the hill at twenty-two.

Paul freezes the frame. James runs the tape. One life, filmed at two moments, by two men who each needed a different frame.

6. The landing

Now the word James actually uses. Not weak. Not immature. Not incomplete.

2:26. "As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead."

Nekra. A corpse. And that analogy is not moral, it is ontological. A body without a spirit is not a person doing badly. It is a corpse. It has the shape of the living thing exactly, every feature in the right place, and it is the opposite of the living thing.

This is where Zizioulas is doing the work, and it is why this passage is not about a ledger at all. The works of love are not a payment laid on top of a nature. They are what the new nature does natively, the way breathing is what a living body does natively. James planted this in chapter 1, verse 18, he chose to give us birth through the word of truth. Chose, and birth. A new birth makes a new nature, and a nature acts. It cannot help acting.

So faith without works is not an unpaid invoice. It is a claimed birth with no family resemblance.

And here is what I want to leave on you, because it is the thing that has bothered me all week.

You cannot detect the demon's faith by checking your beliefs. That is the whole horror of verse 19. The demons pass every doctrinal test. If you audit your creed you will find it correct, and finding it correct will tell you nothing, because correctness is exactly what the dead version has.

There is only one instrument James gives you. Whether anything in you moves toward the person with nothing.

That is not a comfortable place to end and I am not going to pretend otherwise.

Open loop, one sentence: the body is dead in verse 26, and in chapter 3 we find out which organ killed it.